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LOCAL FARMS

At this local family flower farm, it's all hands on deck

By Faith Dorn

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(From left) Sage, Soren, Hannah, Matt and Noah Headley, with Luna the dog. The kids are sitting on rolls of cardboard the Headleys use in the gardening process.

Submitted photo

Heather and Matt Headley own and operate Headley Flower Farm in Anniston, a boutique flower farm that grew from a passion for locally sourced vegetables and flowers.

Matt was the senior pastor at Weaver First United Methodist Church for about seven years, and the Headley family lived in the parsonage, where they enjoyed using a raised garden bed. Matt eventually left his senior pastor role in Weaver and became music director at First United Methodist Church in Anniston. Upon leaving the job in Weaver, the family had to find a new home.



To find out more about Headley Flower Farm, upcoming workshops, or to order flowers, visit www.headleyflowerfarm.com.

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“It was the pandemic, and houses were being sold within 24 hours of being on the market,” said Heather.



Heather wanted to own a farm and land, but she also wanted to be in the city. Finally, she found the property she wanted.

“Our property is in the back of the Lenlock Heights neighborhood, and our property line is the back of Walmart — which has benefits and drawbacks,” Heather said, laughing.

When the Headleys moved to their farm, Heather started planting flower seeds.

“I would cut and give flowers to people. I would see the excitement when I handed people flowers, especially when they weren’t expecting them,” she said.

After experiencing the mutual joy of giving flowers to others, Heather told her husband that she wanted to turn their property into a flower farm.

“Not everybody saw the dream, but people are catching the vision now,” Heather said.



Heather and Matt Headley, owners of Headley Flower Farm in Anniston, believe in working with nature instead of against it.

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All hands on deck

Heather grew up in Pleasant Valley, and her parents had a large kitchen garden and chickens.

“We also learned how to can and harvest. I said I would never have a garden and never have chickens,” Heather said, “Not only do I have a garden, but I have a farm, chickens, two babydoll sheep named Silver and Shadow, a dog named Luna, and we are talking about getting goats and pigs.”

With all of the animal and plant life on the farm, it is an “all hands on deck” situation. This spring, Matt left his position at the church to focus on farming full time. The Headley children — Hannah, 12, Noah, 11, and twins Sage and Soren, 9 — also help with farm tasks

like planting, transplanting, setting up gardening beds and visiting farmers markets. Flowers for this summer include sunflowers, zinnias, marigolds, celosia and cosmos. The Headleys hope to have heirloom pumpkins to sell this autumn.

Headley Flower Farm occasionally hosts flower arranging workshops. The Headleys also do flowers for events. They offer full service wedding flowers, as well as an a la carte option for brides who would prefer to order flowers from a menu.



Matt Headley working in the high tunnel (a lot of people call it a greenhouse). The 96-by 35-foot-wide space offers temperature and climate control, so the Headleys can plant in the fall to have blooms in the spring. If it gets cold, they can close it off and keep the plants nice and warm.

Submitted photo

Respect for nature



Babydoll sheep Silver (back) and Shadow (front) serve in a dual capacity as Headley family pets and lawnmowers. (The Headley children named them after characters from "Sonic the Hedgehog.")

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The guiding belief behind Headley Flower Farm is that working with nature instead of against it is the healthiest for all involved. They use their animals as rotational grazers, and instead of using lawnmowers or other large machinery, Heather and Matt use their animals to fertilize the soil.

"Instead of pesticides, we bring in beneficial insects. We try to plant in a way that brings in birds. This way, we're not putting chemicals in our flowers and soil. We are using nature to rehabilitate what needs to be worked on," Heather said. "Local tree companies will bring their wood chips, and we use that to compost."

The Headleys want their farm to be a place of peace for themselves and others.

"Our vision is to be a sanctuary in the middle of the rush and the hustle and bustle and never stopping. For us, this has been a real sanctuary. Matt went through a mental health crisis last year, and I have health issues, as well. You can come in and forget about the to-do lists and connect with nature," Heather said.



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